

Breaking barriers

Traditionally, life in the railways was seen as appropriate for men, and women were not a part of the workforce. However, the Indian Railways has the remarkable capability to transform itself. Since 1947, there has been a significant increase in the induction of female staff.

From working on the tracks to becoming locomotive pilots, no role is out of bounds and women have successively broken barriers. Some of them, the “first ladies”, a term coined by JL Singh, retired railwayman and secretary of the Rail Enthusiasts’ Society, have been lone warriors. For instance, Priya Prakash became a part of the Accounts Service as early 1957. Jaya Chauhan became the first woman officer of the Railway Protection Force (RPF), a part of its 1984 batch. When M Kalavathy joined the Indian Railway Service of Signal Engineers, and Manju Gupta became a member of the Indian Railway Service of Electrical Engineers, both were the first women to do so. Surekha Yadav was the first-ever female train driver. More recently, Vijaylakshmi Viswanathan became the financial commissioner in 2002.